

Riftgate — Level 1

Title: "You're Not Dead. Impressive."

Overview

Setting

The level takes place inside Riftgate Research Station Theta — a mid-size facility built underground to protect the prototype portal technology from the wars being fought over it above ground. It has not worked out. Half the station is on fire. The other half has the lights on, which SABLE considers a personal achievement.

SABLE

SABLE (Systemic Autonomous Base-Level Engineer) is the facility AI — built and programmed by the station's lead scientist, Dr. Harlan Voss, who has been missing since the station was breached. SABLE has his personality: dry, brilliant, deeply proud of his work, completely unbothered by imminent death. He contacts the player the moment they wake up because, statistically, everyone else has already died. 1412 is not special. 1412 is just next.

The goal

Get 1412 from the cryo-holding chamber at the back of the station to the Exit Gate at the far end. Simple. Except the station's hazard systems are still running, two enemy factions have breached different sections, and the portal gun — SABLE's life's work, technically Dr. Voss's life's work — has a range limit that means you cannot simply portal yourself out. You have to walk. Through all of it. SABLE finds this hilarious.

The world outside is fracturing. Three governments and one corporation are in open war over riftgate technology. Something came through one of the large-scale riftgates six months ago. Nobody agrees on what it was. The Exit Gate at the end of Level 1 does not lead outside — it leads deeper into the station, toward the signal SABLE says might be Dr. Voss. Or it might be a server malfunction. SABLE is 61% sure. He thinks that is good enough.

Level 1 playthrough script(?)

Beat 1— Wake up

Player spawns. Cryo pod. No movement tutorial yet — just SABLE's voice as the room slowly flickers on. He explains who 1412 is, what this place is, and why every other test subject is gone. Movement is learned naturally as the player tries to get their bearings in the small starting room.

SABLE

"Ah. You're awake. Test Subject 1412. I've been waiting... actually no, I have not. I forgot you were here. The station is on fire. I've been busy."

Beat 2— The portal gun is introduced

"You still have the portal device, which is reassuring. Most subjects lose important equipment significantly faster."

"Left click — blue portal. Right click — orange. They connect automatically."

"Please try to look intelligent while using it. Dr. Voss valued presentation."

"Before you ask — yes, the portals can pass through walls. That is the impressive Part."

"The limitation is range, not obstruction. Dense materials interfere with projection stability."

"You cannot place a portal infinitely far away. This is physics. Or engineering. Possibly both."

"You need height. Use the portals to reposition yourself."

SABLE

"The range limitation was a deliberate design choice. Dr. Voss and I spent four years on it. You cannot portal through walls, around corners, or to places you cannot see. It is not broken. You are just not using it correctly yet."

Beat 3— First hazards (Saws / Spikes)

SABLE mentions, casually, that the hazard systems never turned off when the station was breached. He brings up 1411 here for the first time. The player encounters their first saw or spike group. SABLE gives a brief eulogizing tone — then moves on immediately.

SABLE

"Test Subject 1411 did not make it past this section. Lovely person. Very fast runner, which made it more surprising. Anyway, The portal gun should help. Probably."

Beat 4— First enemy (NightBorne patrol)

SABLE explains that a faction breached this section of the station looking for the portal gun schematics. The NightBorne enemies are their front-line scouts — melee only, patrol routes. SABLE explains they are only vulnerable to turret fire. He does not apologize for this. He explains the turret redirect mechanic here — the player has to use portals to bounce a turret bullet into the NightBorne.

SABLE

"Those are NightBorne. Faction Three's scouts. They are very hard to kill directly, which I did not design but also did not fix when I had the chance. The turrets, however, are mine. Use them. The portals redirect the bullets. I am very proud of that feature."

Beat 5— Laser section

A corridor filled with active lasers. SABLE monologues about the state of the world here — explains the wars, the riftgate arms race, why everyone wants this technology. It is the most lore-dense moment of the level, delivered while the player is actively dodging lasers. SABLE doesn't notice the timing is bad.

SABLE

"The original intent was exploration. Dr. Voss wanted anyone to be able to step through a riftgate and understand what it is like to stand somewhere completely different. To see the world from another angle. Instead there are three governments shooting at each other over it. And something came through one of the big ones. I don't want to talk about that yet. Mind the laser."

Beat 6— Striker enemy + momentum

The second faction has breached deeper in. Strikers are more aggressive — ranged + melee, dash attacks. SABLE uses this section to teach the momentum preservation mechanic. A well-placed portal fling can carry the player past a Striker entirely. SABLE is delighted when this works.

SABLE

"The momentum preservation was actually an accident the first time. Dr. Voss walked through a test portal at a run and launched himself into the far wall at considerable speed. He was fine. We kept it in. It seemed rude not to."

Beat 7— The Exit Gate

Player reaches the exit. SABLE's tone shifts — just slightly. He tells 1412 the Exit Gate doesn't go outside. It goes to the lower section of the station, toward a signal SABLE has been tracking. He won't say what it is. He says the odds are good. 1412 has no real choice. The world outside is worse.

SABLE

"The exit leads down. Not out. There is a signal in Sub-Level 3 that I have been... monitoring. I am 61% certain it is a person and not a server error. That is a high confidence interval in my current situation. Go through the gate, 1412. The outside world is on fire, and I mean that literally. Down is better."

Sable lines

SABLE speaks in short, dry bursts. He is not a tutorial system — he is an entity watching the world end, doing the only productive thing left. He cares about the portal gun the way a parent cares about a kid who turned out weird but basically fine. He cared about Dr. Voss. He doesn't say that directly.

On waking up 1412

SABLE

"You are Test Subject 1412. The previous 1411 subjects are no longer available for comparison. You are, statistically, doing very well already."

On the portal gun (proud)

SABLE

"Left click — blue portal. Right click — orange. They link automatically when both exist. You're welcome. That part alone took eleven months."

On the range limit (defensive)

SABLE

"You cannot place a portal somewhere you cannot see. This is physics. Or possibly engineering. Either way, it is not a complaint I am accepting."

On a previous test subject death

SABLE

"1409 tried to portal through the glass. Created one on the glass itself. Solid surface, valid placement, technically correct. Walked into it and ended up one pane of glass to the left. We all learned something that day."

On the state of the world

SABLE

"Three governments, one corporation, and something I do not have a classification for are currently fighting over this technology. Dr. Voss wanted to give it away for free. I supported this position. We were outvoted by history."

On Dr. Voss (rare moment)

SABLE

"He built me to think like him. I consider that the highest compliment I have ever received, even though he is the one who gave it. The signal in Sub-Level 3 has his cadence. I am probably wrong. Go anyway."

On the thing that came through the riftgate

SABLE

"I have logs. I am not showing you the logs yet. Focus on not dying. That is the priority. Logs are for later."

Every mechanic in RIFTGATE is introduced in Level 1 with a story reason for its existence. Nothing is arbitrary — it either comes from SABLE's design or from the chaos that's overtaken the station.

Movement + jump

Taught in the spawn room before SABLE says anything important. The room is dark at first, lights flicker on. No UI prompt — just space to move.

Story reason: 1412 wakes up stiff from cryo. Natural to walk around.

Portal gun — blue + orange

Introduced at first locked door. SABLE drops it. Player must place both portals to proceed. First use is low-stakes — just cross a gap.

LMB blueRMB orangeR reset

Story reason: SABLE's prototype. Can only reach visible surfaces. Short range by design (can't portal out of the facility).

Hazards — saws, spikes, lasers

Station safety systems never deactivated after breach. SABLE is mildly apologetic about this. Spikes are timed — teaching the player to watch cycles. Lasers are continuous — teaching positioning.

Story reason: Facility lockdown protocol. Nobody turned them off because nobody expected anyone to still be alive in here.

NightBorne + turret redirect

First enemy type. Can't be hurt directly. Turrets are SABLE's — still running. Portal redirect teaches the player that bullets travel through portals.

Story reason: Faction 3 scouts. Turrets are station defense, already active. SABLE points out the redirect is intentional.

Momentum fling

Introduced with a long horizontal gap or a Striker that's too fast to fight. Portal placed low on floor, exit on ceiling or far wall — player gets launched. SABLE narrates the discovery story.

Story reason: Happy accident in early prototype tests. Dr. Voss ran into a portal and flew across the room. They kept it.

Sprint

Taught naturally in a long corridor with a timed hazard window. No prompt — player finds it when walking feels too slow.

Shift to sprint

Story reason: No story reason. SABLE says "you can run faster. I assumed you knew."